▼ Students at an anti-Mandal agitation in Delhi

SHARAD SAXENA



ANTI-MANDAL AGITATION, 1990

Pan-India

The Quota Factor

This was a nationwide protest against the implementation of the B.P. Mandal Commission's recommendation of 27 per cent quota in government jobs and public universities for Other Backward Classes (OBCs). The commission was set up in January 1979 by the Morarji Desai government and presented its report to the President in December 1980. Given the existing 22.5 per cent reservation for Scheduled Castes and Tribes, the OBC quota meant nearly 50 per cent government jobs and public university seats would be out of bounds for the general category. The V.P. Singh government decided to implement the recommendation in August 1990, sparking student protests, which began from Delhi University and spread quickly. It turned violent at several places with roads blocked, vehicles targeted, schools and colleges shut and government and public services disrupted. DU student Rajiv Goswami, who attempted self-immolation, became an abiding symbol of the protests. ■

–Kaushik Deka

SHEDDING ALL RESERVATIONS The anti-Mandal agitation ended with Prime Minister V.P. Singh stepping down on November 7, 1990 after the BJP withdrew support to his government

Affirmative Objection

ANTI-RESERVATION PROTESTS, 2006

Delhi, Mumbai



GETTY IMAGES

◀ Medical students at an anti-reservation protest, 2006

In April 2006, the UPA government, through the 93rd Constitutional Amendment, decided to implement 27 per cent reservation for Other Backward Classes (OBCs) in higher education institutes, including central universities, IITs, IIMs and AIIMS, inviting protests from forward class students. Medical students in Delhi took the lead and drew support from their counterparts in other cities, such as Mumbai, and IIT Roorkee students. The protesters organised themselves under the banner of 'Youth for Equality' and demanded a rollback of the quota, a white paper on the reservation policy and alternative ways of affirmative action. ■

–Rahul Noronha

WIN SOME, LOSE SOME: While the agitation paled in comparison to the anti-Mandal protests of the noughties, a key development was the Supreme Court's April 2008 verdict, which upheld the 27 per cent quota but ruled that the OBC 'creamy layer' was not entitled to the benefit.

The protests were led by medical students. In some cities, doctors joined in solidarity and college faculty went on leave